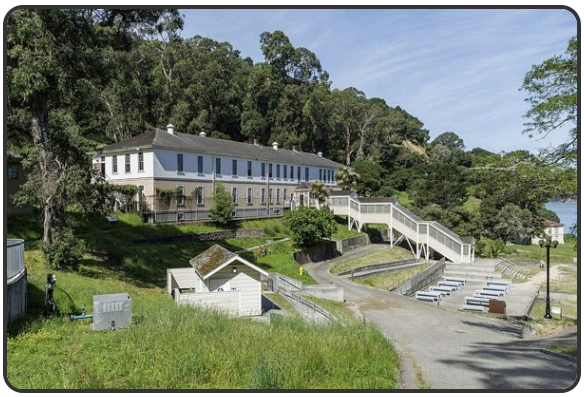
🗽 Immigration & Cities: Reading

US History · Unit 3 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · our own reading

Name: _____

Words to know: ***detain*** *= to hold someone and not let them leave ·* ***interrogation*** *= a long set of questions*



Detention barracks, Angel Island Immigration Station

Angel Island: The Immigration Station in the West

Angel Island sits in San Francisco Bay, California. From 1910 to 1940 it was an **immigration station**, a place where newcomers were checked before entering the U.S. It is sometimes called the “Ellis Island of the West,” but it was very different.

Most detainees were Chinese, though people also arrived from Japan, Korea, India, Russia and Mexico. The **Chinese Exclusion Act** (1882) was the first U.S. law to ban immigration by one nationality. It blocked Chinese laborers; only merchants, students, diplomats, teachers and children of U.S. citizens could legally enter.

In 1906 an earthquake and fire in San Francisco destroyed many birth records. Some Chinese immigrants then came with papers saying they were the children of citizens. They were called **“paper sons”** and **“paper daughters.”**

Officials expected fraud, so they used **interrogations** that could last hours or days. Questions covered tiny details of home villages: how many houses were in a row, which way the house faced, who lived next door. A relative already in the U.S. answered the same questions; any mismatch could mean **deportation**.

At Ellis Island most European immigrants were processed in a few hours. At Angel Island, Chinese immigrants were often **detained** for weeks or months, and some for close to two years, in crowded, locked barracks with little privacy.

Some detainees carved **poems** in Chinese into the wooden walls. More than 200 poems survive. They tell about missing family, anger at unfair treatment, and hope for a new life.

A fire destroyed the administration building in 1940. During World War II, when China was a U.S. ally, Congress repealed the Exclusion Act (1943). Today the station is a National Historic Landmark and state park; the wall poems are preserved as a record of the immigrant experience.

Check your reading

1. Why were Chinese immigrants treated differently from European immigrants at Ellis Island?

2. Explain how the 1906 earthquake led to “paper sons” and to the long interrogations.

3. What do you think was hardest for detainees? Use a detail from the reading.

4. Why is it important that the wall poems were saved?